

Runner Says Sorry After Riding on a Bike During the Berlin Marathon

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A **marathon** is a 42.2-**kilometer** race, about 26.2 miles, and runners are supposed to cover every step on their own feet. But at this year's Berlin **Marathon**, one runner seems to have taken a shortcut on wheels.

A Chinese fitness **influencer** has apologized after photos appeared to show her riding on the back of a bike during the race on Sept. 27. She goes by the name Abeeeeer on the Chinese social media app Rednote, also called Xiaohongshu, where she has 520,000 followers.

The photos were first posted on Oct. 1 by an Instagram account called the Official **Marathon** Time **Integrity** Unit, which points out race results that look **suspicious**. The account noted that her fastest time came between the 35- and 40-**kilometer** marks, around when "she was spotted on the back of a bike."

On Saturday, the **influencer** posted a "sincere apology" for breaking the rules. She said she had felt unwell during the race, but admitted that was not an excuse. "My behaviour to take a shortcut was disrespectful to the spirit of the **marathon**," she wrote. She also said she had hidden the truth when she first shared about the race.

The running shoe company Brooks told CBC News on Tuesday that Brooks China ended its relationship with the runner after checking the facts. "Brooks believes running should be grounded in **integrity**, fairness, and respect for competition," the company said.

CBC News said it had asked the Berlin **Marathon** and the Instagram account for more details but had not yet heard back.

More than 56,000 runners from 162 countries entered this year's race, which has the flattest course of the big World **Marathon** Majors races, making it the fastest. About 50,000 people crossed the finish line.

Word Treasure

influencer -- A person who is popular on social media and can affect what followers think or buy.

marathon -- A running race of 42.2 kilometers, or about 26.2 miles.

suspicious -- Seeming wrong or dishonest in a way that makes people want to check.

integrity -- Being honest and following the rules even when no one is watching.

kilometer -- A unit of distance equal to 1,000 meters, or a little more than half a mile.

Background you need

A marathon is a long-distance running race of 42.2 kilometers, and runners must cover the whole course on foot.

Big city marathons track each runner with timing chips at checkpoints along the course, which lets people spot results that do not make sense.

Cutting part of the course or getting a ride is against the rules because it gives an unfair advantage.

Many athletes and social media stars are supported by sponsors, companies that can end the partnership if the person breaks the rules.

Break it down

LEAD: A marathon runner appears to have taken a shortcut on wheels

KEY EVENT: Chinese fitness influencer Abeeeeer apologizes for riding a bike during the Sept. 27 Berlin Marathon

+ - WHO: The influencer, with 520,000 followers on Rednote

+ - HOW FOUND: Instagram account posted photos Oct. 1 and noted her fastest split

EVIDENCE: Fastest time between 35 and 40 kilometers, when she was spotted on a bike

RESPONSE: Saturday apology; Brooks China ended the relationship after checking facts

OPEN QUESTION: Berlin Marathon and the Instagram account had not yet replied to CBC News

Why it matters

Fair play is what makes races and games meaningful for everyone who follows the rules. The story shows that cheating can be discovered and can cost people trust and partnerships.

Test what you remember

1. What do photos appear to show the influencer doing during the race?

- ☐ (A) Taking a bus
- ☐ (B) Skipping the start
- ☐ (C) Riding on the back of a bike
- ☐ (D) Running backward

2. When was the Berlin Marathon held?

- ☐ (A) Aug. 31
- ☐ (B) Oct. 1
- ☐ (C) Oct. 7
- ☐ (D) Sept. 27

3. Who first posted the photos?

- ☐ (A) The Berlin Marathon
- ☐ (B) CBC News
- ☐ (C) Brooks
- ☐ (D) An Instagram account that points out suspicious race results

4. Between which marks was her fastest time recorded?

- ☐ (A) 35 and 40 kilometers
- ☐ (B) 0 and 5 kilometers
- ☐ (C) 10 and 15 kilometers
- ☐ (D) At the finish line only

5. What reason did she give, while saying it was not an excuse?

- ☐ (A) Her shoes broke
- ☐ (B) She was lost
- ☐ (C) She was late
- ☐ (D) She felt unwell

6. What did Brooks China do?

- ☐ (A) Ended its relationship with her
- ☐ (B) Gave her a prize
- ☐ (C) Hired her again
- ☐ (D) Sponsored the race

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The influencer: Says she felt unwell but admits it was no excuse and that taking a shortcut was disrespectful to the marathon.
2. Brooks: Says running should be grounded in integrity, fairness and respect for competition.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):